Prairie Fire Partners

Designing and Implementing the Prairie Fire Partners Operating System

A permission-aware operating system for a small advisory firm

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October 2026

The operating problem

Prairie Fire Partners (PFP) brings together associates, partners and founders whose work crosses client delivery, venture building, business development and financial decisions.

PFP is a Guild of former twenty seven senior National Security officials and military officers, predominantly from the Special Operations and Intelligence Communities in the US and allied countries, bringing their own community-specific collaborative cultures. The challenge is efficiently realizing the value in the deep domain expertise, in a manner that allows the advisory arm of the business to utilize these $200k-$400k domain experts sparingly- and not doing the work of junior associates or burning hours collaborating across verticals.

Information is spread across meeting transcripts, email, Slack, documents and core services workflows, and AI-enabled deep research scheduled tasks that allow us to efficiently stay abreast of developments in the rapidly evolving technology, regulatory, procurement, capital strategy and political domains.

The problem extends beyond dissemination and accountability: Individual Partners need a clear view of responsibilities, contribution and compensation rules, reliable financial context, and timely intelligence for different audiences. More summaries alone cannot provide that operating clarity. The system needs trustworthy records, explicit access boundaries and accountable decisions.

What I built

I designed and implemented the PFP operating system and its surrounding AI-assisted workflows. The portal provides a structured view of work, while existing collaboration tools remain the places where people supply evidence, review proposals and make decisions. I used AI tools to translate business requirements into designs, implementation work, test cases and revisions, and to support recurring research and review workflows.

My contribution was product and operating-model ownership: defining the problem, selecting priorities, setting access and approval boundaries, reviewing outputs, and directing iterations. Implementation was AI-assisted and involved coding tools; I do not claim to have personally written every line of code.

The central design choice

AI can propose a task, extract a date or prepare an update. It must not turn an ambiguous conversation into a new obligation or disclose an internal record merely because it can retrieve it. We separated evidence, proposed changes, accepted records and external release, with distinct authority at each step.

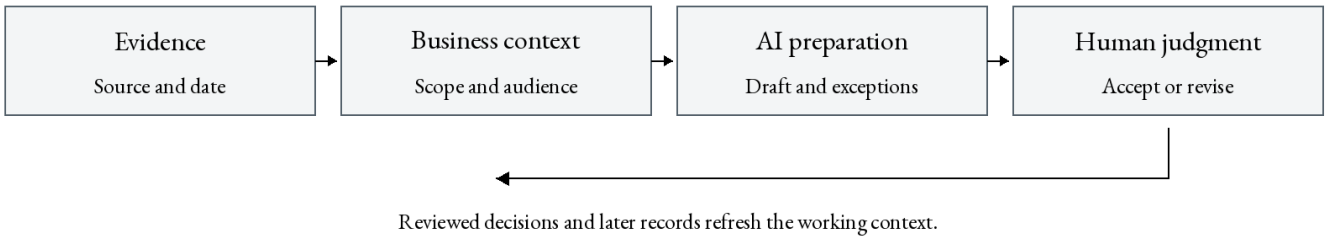
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The sections follow the operating problem on page one: protect expert time, make responsibilities and economics clear, and turn research into useful, permissioned intelligence. Select a linked heading to jump to its section.

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Protecting domain expertise

PFP's partners bring different community-specific collaborative cultures to shared work. The operating design prepares a common project record so senior practitioners can spend their time on interpretation and decisions rather than rebuilding context. PFP captures additional value by adding to the business context through the contributions of these domain experts, enabling improved efficiency in future cycles.



- **Prepare before asking for judgment.** Retain the relevant source, date, prior decision, current document version and unresolved question. Add the customer problem, agreed scope, audience and next decision. A generated note is not a verbatim transcript.
- **Use the expert's correction.** Practitioners correct interpretation and decide what may be acted on or released. An accepted correction informs the next working version; a changed requirement does not silently rewrite the original evidence.
- **Keep the claim bounded.** Reviewed workflow directions and iterative corrections demonstrate human feedback in practice. A fully automated recurring-learning pipeline and complete synchronization across tools and models are not established.

Keeping project context portable

Expert judgment has lasting value when the firm can retain it with the work. The design separates the company's operating knowledge from the particular model used to prepare a draft or answer a question.



Record ownership is the architectural intent. Provider portability and on-premises operation are not verified.

What belongs in the project record

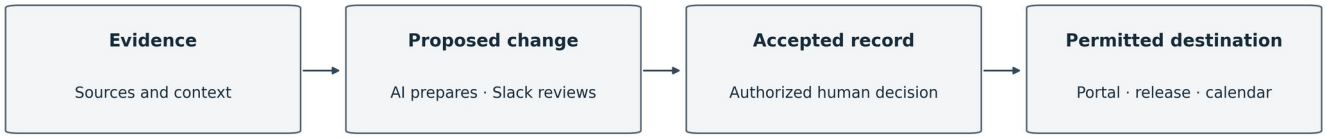
- **Evidence and provenance.** Keep source documents, meeting records, dates and links to supporting evidence. Preserve the difference between a source statement, an interpretation and a decision.
- **Reviewed project context.** Carry agreed scope, accepted corrections, open questions, ownership and audience restrictions into the next task. This is the useful feedback from expert review, rather than a claim that the model itself has learned permanently.
- **Version and authority.** Retain which version was reviewed, who could authorize the decision and the purpose for which reuse was permitted. Prior approval does not authorize every future use.

How that context would travel

- **Scoped handoff.** Provide the relevant approved context for the task and audience, while retaining the company-controlled record as the reference. Do not send the entire project history merely because a tool can access it.
- **Provider optionality.** A portable context layer could support a change of cloud provider or, where privacy and cost justify it, on-premises deployment. Both require validation of access controls, data handling and the usefulness of transferred context.
- **Current boundary.** Company-controlled context and cross-provider reuse are architectural intentions. Cross-provider portability, on-premises operation and a single automatically synchronized context layer have not been verified as shipped capabilities.

Responsibilities across verticals

Clear responsibility across client delivery, venture building, business development and financial decisions reduces repeated coordination. The operating design separates evidence, proposed changes, accepted records and permitted destinations.



A changed proposal returns for review. Each destination has its own action and access gate.

An accepted record is not blanket permission to publish, schedule or commit.

Give each surface a defined job

- **Portal.** Organize accepted work and its permitted views. A task can appear in a project view and a person's work list without becoming two tasks; corrections should retain revision history.
- **Slack review.** Present the evidence, proposed fields, intended audience and side effects. An authorized reviewer accepts the specific change. A revised proposal returns for approval.
- **Conversational AI.** Help people question sources and prepare changes within their own scope. Conversational access to structured records remains an integration design, separate from demonstrated research and code-assistance workflows.

Keep commitments attached to accountable decisions

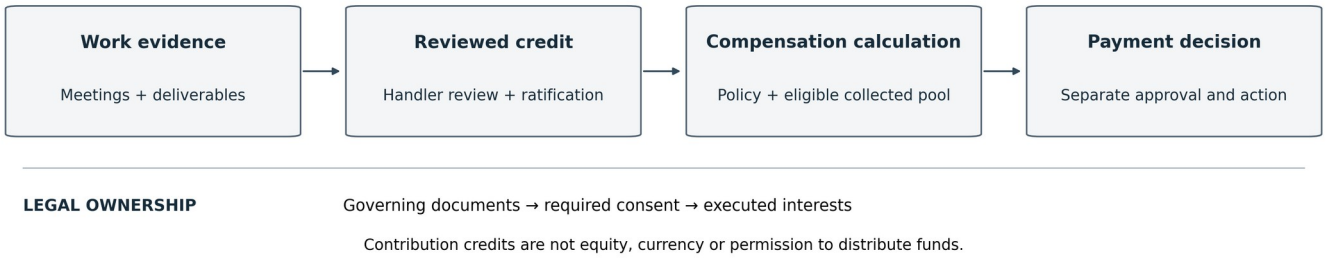
- **Source to proposal.** Meeting records, emails and documents supply evidence. AI can propose an action or date, but ambiguous owners and deadlines remain unresolved until a responsible person accepts them.
- **Proposal to accepted record.** Client feedback enters as a request, rather than directly changing internal scope, commitments or deadlines. An intelligence finding can remain a Watch item without creating a delivery task or application commitment.
- **Record to destination.** A portal view, external release or calendar entry has its own action and access gate. Visibility in a firm work view does not confer access to restricted financial or personnel information.

Make the access boundary hold during use

- **Implemented read controls.** Client reads use server-side scope rather than broad downloads hidden in the browser. Authority is rechecked on refresh, focus and reconnect. Older identity or route responses are fenced off.
- **Visible failure states.** Failed reads are discarded rather than shown as complete mixed results. Authorized empty data stays distinct from denied, offline or incomplete coverage. Bounded navigation does not prove a complete firmwide inventory.

Contribution and compensation rules

Individual partners need to understand how accepted work relates to contribution credit and compensation. PFP's contribution policy and operating agreement supply the rules, while legal ownership interests remain a separate record.



Capture and ratify the whole contribution

- **Work beyond meetings.** Meeting activity provides a starting record alongside asynchronous work and deliverables. Meeting counts alone do not measure the full contribution.
- **Review before credit is locked.** The policy routes submissions through project-handler review and managing-partner ratification for the relevant period. Project and contribution identifiers link delivery to reviewed credit.
- **Partner visibility.** The intended views show each partner their accepted contribution and applicable economics, while restricting firmwide financial and ownership information to authorized reviewers.

Calculate compensation from approved inputs

- **Approved calculation.** Ratified contributions, policy weighting rules and the eligible collected-revenue pool support quarterly compensation. A reviewer checks the calculation and payout package before invoicing or payment.
- **Distinct economics.** Firm overhead, managing-partner compensation, relationship and execution responsibilities, and the shared performance-compensation pool are separate categories. A single partner balance would obscure the rules.
- **Allocation units.** These are internal contribution credits for performance-based contractor compensation. They are not currency, dividends, membership interests or equity, and an approved balance does not authorize a distribution.

Keep ownership legally grounded

- **Governing documents.** Link proposed equity allotments, required consents and executed records. PFP membership interests are separate from equity held in client companies. Admission and new interests require the consent specified by the operating agreement.
- **State and authority.** Keep proposed, approved and legally executed positions distinguishable. A database update cannot substitute for a required signature or consent. These rules guide the design; not every contribution, finance or equity workflow is deployed end to end.

Reliable financial context

The Friday managing-partner review brings pipeline, delivery and financial decisions together. PFP has prepared private finance read-aheads and management decks for that cadence. The operating design connects those materials to accounting evidence, engagement context and partner economics.



Make the economic picture decision ready

- **Management snapshot.** Start with customer cash receipts, year-to-date expenses and a defined management result, then available cash, obligations, partner payouts and decisions required. Bridge that view to the accounting books; cash receipts and accrual revenue are not interchangeable.
- **Commercial context.** Separate prospective pipeline from contracted engagements and collected revenue. Bring delivery commitments, collection questions and upcoming obligations into the same review so the next decision and its owner are visible.
- **Visible exceptions.** Transfers and financing inflows are not customer revenue. A bank balance is not automatically distributable cash. Incomplete coverage, unsettled payments and unresolved classifications remain reconciliation questions, not confident margin or runway claims.

Review the treatment before changing the books

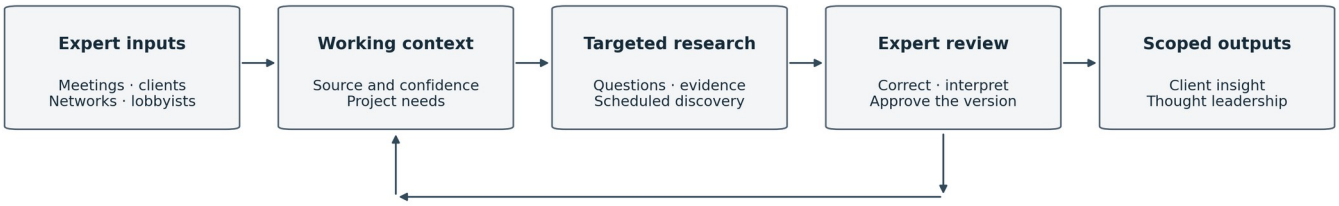
- **Prepare the candidate.** Use the transaction, supporting document, business purpose and prior treatment to propose a classification or journal entry. Distinguish operating expense, delivery cost and interest; route uncertainty to an exception list.
- **Approve and verify.** The responsible reviewer sees accounts, amounts and evidence before a permitted write. A changed treatment returns for approval. Check resulting and existing records before retrying so an uncertain outcome cannot become a duplicate posting or payout.
- **Separate reporting from execution.** A report can identify a payment, agreement or collection issue without authorizing a transfer, changing terms or sending a client message. A reviewed compensation calculation and a payment remain separate steps.

Current operating boundary

Financial reporting and review workflows provide the operating pattern. One synchronized portal view of every financial input remains the integration design. The intended value is less repeated preparation and a shorter path to a useful decision through consistent definitions and explicit exceptions.

Expert informed research and feedback

PFP’s domain experts bring technology, procurement, capital, politics and regulation, and tactics, techniques and procedures (TTPs) expertise. Their judgment enriches project context and sharpens AI-enabled deep research and scheduled tasks.



Reviewed corrections refine context and the next research question. This is not autonomous model learning.

Bring expert insight into the working context

- **Meetings and client conversations.** Capture observations, corrections and questions from transcripts and authorized client conversations. Distinguish recorded words from interpretation; retain the project need, date and source.
- **Relationships and networks.** Personal relationships and network “word on the street” reveal leads to test, not publishable facts. Record confidence and limits without exposing confidential contacts or clients.
- **Politics and regulation.** PFP lobbyist insights add political and regulatory context. Reconcile them with public evidence and source permissions before client-facing use or thought leadership.

Use an expert informed feedback loop

- **Qualify and focus.** Review source quality, confidentiality and relevance. Accepted input refines context, research criteria and questions across the five domains, including TTPs. Keep unverified observations separate from accepted decisions.
- **Research and challenge.** Use refined context for scheduled discovery and deeper research. Experts test interpretations, correct terminology and add evidence. Carry reviewed corrections into the next version and research question.
- **Approve and reuse.** Prepare client insights, opportunity assessments and thought leadership for the intended audience. Approve the exact version before release; reuse only permitted context with provenance and access boundaries intact.

Separate operating practice from intended integration

- **Demonstrated and configured.** Daily discovery, reviewed item/PDF publication and expert-driven draft revisions are evidenced. Weekly synthesis is configured to begin November 16, 2026.
- **Intended extension.** A consistent loop across all inputs and outputs is the design. Complete automatic synchronization and autonomous model learning are not established. Improved future cycles are the aim, not a quantified result.

From expert review to approved intelligence

The demonstrated workflow combines scheduled discovery with project context, expert review and exact-version approval. It produces a permitted news item and matching brief, with verification after publication.



Reviewed corrections inform the next version. Automatic context synchronization is not established.

One demonstrated publication

- **Discover and interpret.** A scheduled research workflow surfaced an official battery-performance study. The draft related it to a client's simulation and test-tooling work, while flagging dataset availability, access terms and applicability as unverified.
- **Approve and verify.** A human approved the exact news package on November 9. A November 10 receipt recorded publication and readback; subsequent inspection confirmed the live news record and linked PDF. This demonstrates reviewed publication, not autonomous publishing or measured business impact.

Expert input changes the working context

- **Correct and reconcile.** An expert supplied an official competition link. The revised proposal reconciled it with existing discovery, prepared exact Watch-record fields and retained deadline and readiness holds before a separate approval request.
- **Use the next version.** Source additions, terminology corrections and status changes inform the next version. Another rewritten brief remained unpublished pending support for political and commercial claims. These exchanges demonstrate review-driven refinement; automatic propagation across models and systems is not established.

Keep opportunity and release decisions distinct

- **Opportunity gates.** A candidate records its source, deadline, mechanism, eligibility and IP conditions while leaving technical fit unresolved. One verified proposal remained a Watch recommendation, with later publication unverified. It did not authorize application, spending, task assignment or technical work.
- **Permitted delivery.** Approval applies to the exact item, matching PDF and audience. Material changes return for review. Client-scoped reads and server-enforced controls are implemented; record and PDF readback do not establish a complete production access-control audit or fully synchronized portal.